



General Assembly

Substitute Bill No. 5270

February Session, 2026



***AN ACT EXTENDING FINANCIAL ASSISTANCE FOR THE
POSTSECONDARY EDUCATION EXPENSES OF FOSTER YOUTH.***

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Assembly convened:

- 1 Section 1. (NEW) (*Effective July 1, 2026*) (a) As used in this section:
- 2 (1) "Department" means the Department of Children and Families;
- 3 (2) "Postsecondary education program" means any program that
- 4 leads to an academic degree or certification in a vocation or employment
- 5 training; and
- 6 (3) "Postsecondary education funding program" means the program
- 7 set forth in department policy 28-1 under which it funds the
- 8 postsecondary education of a youth who is committed to the
- 9 department, remains committed at the age of eighteen and meets the
- 10 requirements established by the department in its policies and
- 11 regulations.
- 12 (b) The Commissioner of Children and Families shall amend the
- 13 department policies and regulations regarding the postsecondary
- 14 education funding program to (1) increase the age until which a youth
- 15 can qualify for funding from the department under the postsecondary
- 16 education funding program from twenty-one to twenty-six years of age,
- 17 (2) increase the age until which a youth who is enrolled in a

18 postsecondary education program and continues to meet the
19 requirements established by the department is eligible for funding to
20 complete such postsecondary education program under the
21 postsecondary education funding program from twenty-three to
22 twenty-eight years of age, and (3) require any youth who is eligible for
23 funding under the postsecondary education funding program to
24 complete for each year such youth is enrolled in a postsecondary
25 education program, as a condition to receiving such funding, the Free
26 Application for Federal Student Aid and applications for any
27 appropriate scholarships and grants, including, but not limited to,
28 through any scholarship application portal administered by the
29 provider of such postsecondary education program. Nothing in this
30 section shall be construed to require the department to continue
31 providing case management services for any youth who begins
32 receiving funding under the postsecondary education funding program
33 when such youth is older than twenty-one years of age.

This act shall take effect as follows and shall amend the following sections:		
Section 1	<i>July 1,2026</i>	New section

KID

Joint Favorable Subst. C/R

APP